The Lantern Keeper

Chapter One: The Long Winter

The house had been empty for eleven years, and yet the lamp in the upstairs window still burned every night. Mira had noticed it first from the road, a small orange seed against the dark blue. She assumed it was a reflection, or a trick of the glass.

It was neither.

Chapter Two: A Room of Paper

Inside, the rooms smelled of cedar and old rain. Books climbed the walls in uneven towers. On the desk lay a ledger filled with careful handwriting, each entry a date and a name and the weather.

The last entry was dated the night her brother disappeared.